

often feels a generation too soon.

"Unfortunately, it's a game of runs and wickets," Rathnayake tells *Sportstar*. "Look at just the batting. We've wanted to elevate the others to Chamari's level, and we had some heartening results. We narrowed that difference a lot. I just wish everyone got to see that a lot more on the big stage."

The mood is reminiscent of the 2024 T20 Asia Cup campaign, which Sri Lanka won by beating India in the final. That tournament, too, was about finding answers beyond Athapaththu, who had begun hinting that her international career was nearing its end.

Harshitha Samarawickrama and Kavisha Dilhari carried Sri Lanka home then, while Athapaththu, like a mother watching her children in a school final, nervously bit her nails on the sidelines. These are the faces of Sri Lanka's future, but for all the promise, consistency remains elusive.

This World Cup feels markedly different from the 2022 edition in New Zealand. For one, Sri Lanka wasn't even there, having played no ODIs in the lead-up to that tournament because of the pandemic. Since then, the team has played 36 ODIs and won 12 — a modest but meaningful improvement.

The Harshithas, Vishmis, and Kavishas have been the focus of Sri Lanka's rebuild, while bowlers such as Vihanga and Malki Madara have been blooded. But the gulf between the senior pros and the emerging generation is still evident to the coach. "We are aware that the ladies start cricket a bit late, so age is not a big issue," Rathnayake told this publication during the T20 World Cup in the UAE last year.

"We try to encourage youngsters coming through, and the board has arranged key opportunities for youngsters to show themselves off. The actual fruit of that exercise will come through in another five years. For us here, though, the challenge is upskilling our group."

The problem, of course, is that upskilling cannot, and should not, happen during a World Cup.



Step by step

Shashikala Siriwardene, Sri Lanka's first bona fide star and Athapaththu's predecessor as captain, recalls how passion once powered the sport in a landscape with little financial incentive.

Her own journey began with her father's quiet commitment to her early coaching — a small act of belief that mirrored many others across the island. For players like Athapaththu, it was often an uncle or a relative who filled that role, people who trusted a system that had yet to take shape.

"It was a struggle to demonstrate to our people our ability to play cricket, making it challenging to maintain the team's cohesion. Each individual faced their own unique set of difficulties," she tells *Sportstar*.

It also took visionaries who thought well ahead of their time to fight for the women's game to be seen on its own merit, separate from the men's structure. One such pioneer was Gwen Herath, the founding president of the Sri Lanka Women's Cricket Association, who passed away earlier this year. She rallied funds for the team, brought in the appliance brand Singer as a sponsor, and ensured Sri Lanka made it to the 1997 World Cup in India.

Defining triumph

Sri Lanka batters celebrate their historic win over India in the 2024 Women's T20 Asia Cup final, a landmark triumph that signalled the team's intent to step out from Chamari Athapaththu's shadow and script its own chapter in the women's game. GETTY IMAGES

When compared with Pakistan and Bangladesh, where domestic fixtures are irregular, Sri Lanka benefits from a long-standing club ecosystem. Representation from the Armed Forces — Army, Navy, and Air Force — has historically provided a steady supply of players who later graduated to the national side.

Today, clubs serve as the first tier of the pathway, feeding players into provincial teams that compete in the National Super League (instituted in 2024).

"There was a significant increase in cricket activity over time. Initially, there were approximately six to eight matches annually, involving six or seven clubs. Additionally, two to three schools participated in cricket. However, with the advent of district and provincial tournaments, as well as 50-over, T20, NSL, and school cricket, the number of clubs and opportunities thereafter has grown,"